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Cohesion, Exile, Return: Non-Human Narrative and the Shape of Diaspora Community in *Never Let Me Go*

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ABSTRACT

This article argues that *Never Let Me Go* employs non-human narrative to depict the clones' brief life journeys, thereby sketching how a plural diaspora community takes shape. Departing from studies that confine diasporic subjecthood to humans, it situates diaspora theory within the clones' experience of cohesion, exile, and return, and examines the different forms of community emerging from this process. The Hailsham homeland community, composed of clones under human governance, foregrounds its internal complexity and the dual instability of homeland and identity. After graduating from Hailsham, the clones move into a condition of exile in which a memory community begins to form, as a process of fragmentation and consolidation forges emotional bonds and sustains beliefs among diasporic subjects. Through the spatial image of the Norfolk fields as a "non-place," Kathy undertakes an imaginative return to community and reconstructs a spiritual homeland after the loss of her close companions and childhood home. This article shows that, on the one hand, Kazuo Ishiguro articulates a plural and inclusive vision of diasporic identity, and, on the other, uses non-human narrative to map the possibilities for imagining community as a reparative response to vulnerability.

Introduction

In his Northcliffe Lecture at University College London in March 2025, Kazuo Ishiguro described *Never Let Me Go* as "a very important departure" in his writing. He recalled that "for a long time when I was writing novels, I thought in terms of characters and narrative and plot. But at a certain point, I stopped thinking in terms of individual characters. I started to think in terms of relationships that connected the characters."[1] He likened this shift to a moment in jazz history when musicians stopped thinking in terms of chords and began to think in terms of scales and notes. From this perspective, the novel does not simply follow a few characters through their separate trajectories, but invites the reader to attend to the web of relationships that structures its world. Within this web, the shifting emotional bonds among Kathy, Ruth and Tommy, the pedagogical and disciplinary ties between guardians and their clone students, and the connections that the clones maintain after leaving Hailsham through shared memories, together compose a layered and tense configuration. It is through the unfolding of these relationships that the characters come to understand and locate themselves and that different shapes of community gradually emerge.

Read in this way, Ishiguro's *Never Let Me Go* repeatedly prompts readers to reflect on concepts of community and identity. Narrated retrospectively by Kathy H., the novel traces her life from childhood at the boarding school of Hailsham, through the intermediate period at the Cottages, to her later work as a "carer" for donors in late twentieth-century England. As she looks back on these stages, she

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slowly discloses both the intimate ties among the children and the system that governs their existence as clones who have been brought into being in order eventually to "donate" their organs and "complete." From the opening pages, Kathy frequently reminisces about her childhood friends and their shared life at Hailsham, recounting these memories to other donors. A donor who grew up elsewhere, conscious of his impending end, expresses a desire to "*remember* Hailsham, just like it had been his own childhood," and asks Kathy to "describe things to him, so they'd really sink in, so that maybe during those sleepless nights, with the drugs and the pain and the exhaustion, the line would blur between what were my memories and what were his" (Ishiguro, *Never Let Me Go* 5–6). Thus, the scene introduces readers to three forms of community: the tangible homeland community of Hailsham where Kathy and her friends lived as children; the memory community formed in diaspora after their departure, sustained through shared recollections and narrated experience; and the imagined revisitation of a spiritual community during the final stage of life, with each character relying on a particular medium.

Ishiguro's dynamic shaping of community is closely interwoven with identity. Toward the end of the novel, Miss Emily reveals to Kathy and her friends their identities as clones, stating that before Hailsham's establishment, "all clones – or *students*, as we preferred to call you – existed only to supply medical science" (261). The designation "students" seems, at least at a certain stage, to mark a form of human solicitude toward non-human subjects, whereas "existed only to supply medical science" starkly exposes the deprivation of the clones' right to life and the extent to which their bodies are disciplined and instrumentalized. The tension between this naming of the clones and the function assigned to them raises a set of questions that lie close to the novel's central concerns: are the boundaries between humans and clones in fact clearly drawn? Must relations between humans and clones be confined to a binary of antagonism and servitude? If clones possess neither nationality nor a status recognized by dominant discourses, can there nevertheless be a diaspora community that is not anchored in state or nation? Can the plural shapes that diaspora community may take help to establish a sense of identity for those living in diaspora? This article takes these questions as its point of departure. It reads *Never Let Me Go* through the intertwined lenses of diaspora, community, and non-human narrative in order to examine how clone identity and human – non-human relations are imagined, and how future forms of community are tentatively sketched in a globalized context. By triangulating diaspora, human, and clone, the discussion traces how this interplay unsettles received understandings of identity and community. It also situates this reading within Ishiguro's wider engagement with diaspora across his oeuvre, where questions of homeland, belonging, and multiple identities recur in different forms.

With the acceleration of globalization in the mid-twentieth century, diasporic culture and literatures have drawn sustained attention across the humanities and social sciences, so that the emergent forms of diasporic writing, together with their new cultural implications, have become a recurrent focus of literary criticism. In his earlier novels, such as *A Pale View of Hills* and *When We Were Orphans*, Ishiguro turns to the shadow of the Second World War to chart the vicissitudes of transnational diasporic lives shaped by the desire to escape conflict and poverty, and to trace the fragile attachments and hard-won continuities that persist amid historical upheaval. By contrast, in his sixth novel, *Never Let Me Go*, he departs from the reassuring firmness of a recognizable historical setting. He constructs a late-1990s Britain in which clones live out abbreviated lives under an organ donation programme, rendering the diasporic textures of their existence and bringing into focus the uneasy boundary between the human and the non-human. In doing so, the novel opens up a space to consider how identity and community are negotiated when lives are curtailed and bodies are treated as resources.

Critics have approached these questions of identity and community from a range of theoretical perspectives. Robbie B. H. Goh foregrounds its postcolonial concerns, describing *Never Let Me Go* as a "prototypical 'postclone-nial'" narrative in which "[t]he postcolonial subject's struggle toward authentic identity and self-articulation within the web of perpetuating neocolonial influences and inequities is thus sharply embodied in the clone's dilemma" (50). In turn, Robinson Murphy shifts the

emphasis from postcolonial identity to questions of responsibility and care, arguing that Ishiguro "charges his readers, by way of his clones, to expand their horizon of care beyond the self, beyond their immediate communities, and indeed to the unseen other" and to enter into "kinship arrangements with nonhuman others" (105). Peter Sloane develops this line of inquiry further in a posthumanist direction, suggesting that the novel does not invite readers to understand the clones as fully human individuals, but that its affective power derives instead from a "shared posthumanity" rooted in the clones' lack of "futurity, fertility, self-actuation" (Shaw and Sloane 12). Taken together, these readings trace a movement from postcolonial subjectivity, through an ethics of care toward human and non-human others, to a conception of shared posthumanity. Yet comparatively little attention has been paid to the diasporic condition of the clones or to the specific ways in which community is configured and reconfigured as they move from Hailsham to the Cottages and then to different donation centers. Taking Ishiguro's own emphasis on relationships as a point of departure, my analysis traces how networks of relation are formed in the unfolding of the narrative: between human beings and non-human clones, among the clones themselves, between the three stages of their lives and the changing shapes of diaspora community, and between individual subjects, their memories and their sense of the future. I read the clones not only as embodiments of postcolonial dispossession, but also as a non-human diaspora community in the midst of dispersal, whose lives, under the human institutions that govern them, are organized around extraction and premature death. By bringing these relational patterns into view, the article asks how, under such "non-human" conditions, different forms of diaspora community are imagined, lived and remembered, and how they in turn shape Ishiguro's ongoing exploration of memory and relationships across his writing career.

Building on this body of work, this article does not seek to provide a new ontological definition of the non-human that would settle what kind of beings the clones "really" are. Rather, it understands "non-human" as a status produced within the novel's historical and institutional setting. As Madhumita Kundu observes, the Hailsham students are in many respects raised like human children, yet they are refused "the needed fundamental equality" that would acknowledge them as fully human (133). At the same time, as David P. Rando argues, they also resist conventional modes of representing non-human characters and are "too human to fall neatly within the equally well-established conventions for representing nonhuman animals" (475). Ishiguro's clones occupy a liminal position on the spectrum between human and non-human, a position that exposes the violence of human exceptionalism and invites readers to rethink the boundaries of the human. In biological and affective terms, however, the clones are indistinguishable from other humans. It is the human society represented in the novel, including the state, the medical system and the guardians who serve them, that classifies the clones as other, denies them legal and political recognition, and reduces them to "students," "donors" and eventually "completed" bodies. The clones are deprived of freedom, basic rights, equality and any open future, including the possibility of reproduction and of living anything like a complete human life. The human – non-human binary that results is therefore not treated here as a stable division between different kinds of beings, but as an institutional mechanism of othering that disavows kinship, legitimizes extractive forms of power and organizes the clones' curtailed lives around exploitation and premature death. I retain the terminology of "human" and "non-human" in order to analyze how the novel constructs and unsettles this binary, how far the clones internalize or contest the status assigned to them, and how, under these "non-human" conditions, they may be read as a colonized and exploited community whose diasporic forms of life call for closer scrutiny. This institutional account of the non-human underpins my use of diaspora theory and informs the questions I ask about community.

As Robin Cohen defines diaspora, "*members of a defined group have been dispersed to many destinations; they construct a shared identity; they still somewhat orient themselves to an original 'home'; and they demonstrate an affinity with other members of the group dispersed to other places*" (1). This definition assumes that diaspora concerns human groups who share an identity and a common home. It does not explicitly rule out non-human diasporic subjects, but non-human subjects such as clones remain largely absent from this account. This article departs from this

anthropocentric understanding of diaspora by reading Ishiguro's non-human narrative through a diasporic lens and treating the clones' experience as emblematic of broader patterns of displacement and unbelonging. Through this attention to community, *Never Let Me Go* shows how different shapes of community are formed around the clones, and extends discussions of diaspora beyond human subjects to whom they have usually been confined.

Tracing the clones' trajectory from cohesion through exile to return, this article explores the shifting shapes of diaspora community in *Never Let Me Go* across three interrelated stages. First, it examines Hailsham as a cohesive homeland community that holds the clones together, and considers how, under the banner of education and care, this institution in fact controls and disciplines the clones, lending Hailsham its particular complexity. It then turns to the condition of exile the clones enter after graduating from Hailsham, and shows how this shift gives rise to a memory community that, in its different forms, offers hope and consolation to those living in dispersal. Finally, the discussion focuses on Kathy's return, exploring how her visits to the Norfolk fields, figured as a "non-place," enable an imaginative revisiting of community and the reconstruction of a spiritual homeland in the wake of the losses of her closest companions. In the course of analyzing cohesion, exile, and return, I draw on the work of Chinese scholars such as Biwu Shang, Ming Tong and Jingrong Zhao, whose analyses of diaspora, community, memory and human – non-human relations, first developed in Chinese, provide a critical counterpoint to Anglophone criticism.[2] These studies grow out of intellectual and historical contexts shaped by Chinese experiences of migration and contemporary Chinese discourse on "a community with a shared future for humankind." They also shape how community and home are conceived, and how relations of interdependence and mutual reliance between human and non-human life are imagined. I place these Chinese-language studies in dialogue with Anglophone theoretical work in order to widen the critical frame beyond Western traditions and to recognize more fully the non-Anglophone scholarship that has already accumulated in this field. For a Chinese critic writing in English, working across these two bodies of scholarship is also a way of inhabiting, at the level of method, the diasporic condition that the novel itself imagines. Read together with Western theoretical frameworks and close reading of *Never Let Me Go*, these perspectives show how different forms of community enable identity formation and the imagining of home for diasporic subjects. Given his position as a Japanese-born British writer, Ishiguro's fiction already unsettles simple oppositions between "East" and "West" and lends itself to readings across different linguistic and regional contexts. On this basis, I argue that Ishiguro's own diasporic ties to Japan and the United Kingdom shape his representations of Hailsham and Norfolk as locations marked by histories of displacement and by the forms of attachment that sustain community. These representations not only open up questions of identity in diasporic settings but also turn the novel toward larger concerns about the brevity of life, the ethics of life-extension and what counts as a fully human existence, figured through the curtailed life courses of the clones.

Cohesion: Construction of the Hailsham Homeland Community

Amid what has been described as the "non-human turn" in the humanities and social sciences, critics have revisited the relations between human and non-human life. Following Nandita Biswas Mellamphy, I understand the intellectual history behind these relations in terms of a basic asymmetry: "Historically, humanistic conceptions are based on asserting the priority of humans; non-humans are viewed as means to human ends" (15). On this view, "non-human" does not name a biological type, but a position within a hierarchy in which certain lives are treated as instruments for the survival, comfort or improvement of others. However, recent work on posthumanism and non-human narrative has explored how such hierarchies might be unsettled and reconfigured. Timothy Lenoir's account of the posthuman stresses that human and non-human life emerge within co-evolutionary, socially regulated networks, and that the posthuman is not simply the product of technological determinism but a "hybrid entity" formed through these networks (210). Biwu Shang, for instance, argues that non-human narratives do not overturn the claim that "literature is a study of humanity,"

but deepen our understanding of the relations between humans and non-humans (122).[3] Building on these insights, my analysis turns to Ishiguro's clones in order to ask what happens when diaspora and community no longer presuppose human subjects. Rather than aligning the clones straightforwardly with any single already familiar marginalized human group, I read them as institutionally produced non-human subjects whose curtailed lives expose how the category of the "human" is defined so as to place them outside it. As Ishiguro notes in an interview regarding the novel's creative vision, *Never Let Me Go* serves as a "metaphor for how we all live" (Freeman 197), and he uses the clones' brief lives to ask "[h]ow do we fit things like love, work, and friendship into what is a surprisingly short period of time" (Wong and Crummett 214). These questions are addressed to human as well as non-human existence, not confined to questions of cloning and clone technology. Reading *Never Let Me Go* through the combined lenses of non-human narrative, diaspora and community therefore makes it possible to examine more closely what humans and non-humans share, and to trace how shifting forms of community are organized around, and in turn unsettle, lives that have been formally classified as "non-human."

Community is a central concept in Western philosophy, and in his depiction of Hailsham, Ishiguro also almost imperceptibly shapes a homeland community for the clones. In *Community & Society*, Ferdinand Tönnies traces the term "community" from a linguistic perspective, arguing that its essence lies in a group formed through a "positive type of relationship," representing a "real and organic life" (33). He categorizes communities into community by blood, community of locality, and community of mind, and holds that what characterizes community is intimate union. In *Never Let Me Go*, Hailsham is one of the homes where clones live together, forming a community of locality. However, Hailsham is isolated and highly enclosed, representing human control over the rights of the non-human, a selfish act of dominating other species to extend human life, an act that Michel Foucault refers to as "*a biopolitics of the population*" (139). Zygmunt Bauman, when discussing the concept of community, states that "community is a 'warm' place, a cosy and comfortable place" (1). On one hand, Hailsham serves as a warm and affectionate homeland that fosters the clones' cohesion; on the other, it is a cruel prison in which humans exercise biopolitical control over non-human life. Thus, power and harmony, control and compliance, become paradoxical labels synonymous with Hailsham, and the negotiation and dialogue between these forces collectively shape the identity of the clones.

Ishiguro's portrayal of Hailsham as a warm and sheltered way of life is first unfolded through Kathy's retrospective narration. The novel does not begin by disclosing her non-human status to the reader. Instead, it opens with her voice in the role of a "carer." Ishiguro is not primarily concerned to foreground cloning technology or science-fiction spectacle. Rather, by attending to how Kathy and her companions live, feel, and make sense of their curtailed futures, he offers an oblique reflection on an ordinary human life lived under the pressure of limited time. Although the clones share no bonds of blood, Kathy's homeland is, for her, both materially situated and imaginatively made. As Ming Tong observes, "homeland is not necessarily the place one has left behind; it can also be a place one attaches to through trans-ethnic ties, driven by the needs of political resistance and cultural identity" (54).[4] Kathy's identity is intricately linked to her construction of homeland. In her narrative, many places constitute her homeland, including the children's dormitory "groups," Hailsham itself, the Cottages after relocation, and Norfolk. Hailsham is the childhood homeland in which she grows up with Ruth and Tommy together, and it becomes a durable emotional bond within their shared memory. Hailsham also places particular emphasis on the cultivation of art and on the cherishing of feeling, through regular drawing classes, and through the provision of "collections" in which students keep small, treasured possessions. Yet this beautiful, intensely cohesive home is also set apart from the outside world. When describing Hailsham, Kathy notes, "Hailsham stood in a smooth hollow with fields rising on all sides" (*Never Let Me Go* 34), and she repeatedly recalls the fear that surrounded the woods beyond the boundaries. Even though paths lead outward, the students' contact with the outside remains severely limited: the monthly Sales, and Miss Emily's geography lessons about

Britain. This enclosure makes the clones aware of their separation from human society and from the surrounding environment. At the same time, it produces the local, place-based conditions of the Hailsham homeland community, where enforced cohesion and a "cosy" childhood atmosphere together shape the clones' sense of identity and belonging.

Through his detailed depiction of Kathy, Ruth and Tommy's friendship and formative years at Hailsham, Ishiguro seeks to articulate the complex character of the Hailsham homeland community. First, this complexity appears in the school's founding rationale. Hailsham is a privately funded experiment within the cloning programme, presented as a humane project that cultivates the students' talents and secures their healthy development in a boarding-school environment before they begin donating organs. However, this ostensible benevolence also functions as a mask for a deeper hypocrisy. Built upon deception, Hailsham mobilizes partial knowledge, carefully cultivated surroundings, and an aesthetic of care to soften, and in some measure legitimize, the system's control over clone lives, encouraging the students to accommodate themselves to an ending already written. In this respect, Hailsham is at once a nursery for the clones' development and a site where a hierarchy is quietly rehearsed, one that places human life above non-human life. Kelly Rich describes this deception as "Hailsham's Paradoxical Infrastructure" (634), suggesting that Hailsham "dramatizes a long-standing belief in an environment's ameliorative effects on personal development," and thus offers the clones a way of making a provisional accommodation with a world that appears alien, indifferent, fragmented, and oppressive (635).

Second, Hailsham's complexity lies in the sharply divergent attitudes it elicits from humans and from clones. For the clone community, Hailsham is an object of longing and admiration. Those raised there receive schooling and are granted regular access to goods from the outside world, advantages that mark them off from clones brought up elsewhere. For humans, by contrast, Hailsham is less a moral commitment than a political performance, a project sustained insofar as it attracts support and investment, and abandoned once the climate of opinion shifts, revealing a deeper indifference: "clones, from the moment of their birth, stand in an unequal relation to humans; they possess their own emotions and memories, culture and art, and social interaction, yet do not integrate with the human world" (Zhi 117). The human – clone relation thereby points toward a bleak horizon of complete instrumentalization and privatization. As Peter Boxall argues, the long history of attempts to master the environment has brought us to a point where "the human itself can only be contemplated from elsewhere, from some posthuman perspective" (127), so that projects designed to secure life also unsettle what counts as human in the first place. This instability also inflects the novel's treatment of Hailsham, not least in the divergent ways it is regarded by the human characters within the story and by readers outside it.

Third, Hailsham's complexity also emerges in the range of responses it elicits from readers, whose position as human spectators partly mirrors that of the novel's human observers. Ishiguro chooses Kathy as a first-person narrator and has her recount a life that moves from Hailsham's "golden" childhood years toward an increasingly dim future. This first-person perspective, together with Ishiguro's characteristically restrained narrative manner, draws readers quietly into the clones' world. Such involvement enables what James Phelan calls "an underlying constructive authorial purpose which gives the story *a thematic, ethical, and* affective significance and force which real world experience does not have" (69). Ishiguro's delayed disclosure of the clones' status further narrows the distance between reader and clone, blurring the boundary between human and non-human and loosening any simple master – slave or adversarial frame through which their relation might otherwise be read. In doing so, it also renders human attitudes toward Hailsham unstable and variously inflected rather than singular or settled. At the same time, the novel's deferral of revelation prompts the fundamental question posed by Peter Sloane: "must something be human in order to be worthy of our identification and empathy, and, perhaps more importantly, social justice?" ("Empathy and the Ethics" 148). This, in turn, brings Hailsham's complicity into sharper focus. It offers the clones a place to learn, to grow, and to belong, while also requiring them, under institutional discipline and the human gaze, repeatedly to "perform" their humanity. Hailsham homeland complexity, then,

resides not only in the novel's intricate plot and relationships but also in the dynamic relation between the story-world and the reader who is drawn into it.

The Hailsham homeland community is not a spontaneously formed, naturally stable space of belonging, but can be seen as a carefully engineered colonial space at the margins of human society, shaped and constrained by extractive forms of human power. It gathers the clones into an apparently safe and affectionate environment while at the same time, through their isolation, excluding them from wider social and national communities, communities that nonetheless depend on the clones' bodies in order to sustain themselves. As Nami Shin observes, "*Never Let Me Go* interrogates the limits of the nation's social imagination by reminding us how the boundaries of the nation's imagined community tend to exclude certain others" (385). I suggest that this boundary is caught in a cruel paradox. At the level of feeling, the line between the clones and "us" is drawn with great clarity. At the level of the body, however, that line disappears, since human bodies rely on the clones' organs for cure and for the extension of life. This boundary, at times sharply enforced and at other times effaced, also generates confusion and debate among the clones within Hailsham itself. The most striking example is the scene in which the children test how Madame really sees them. They deliberately huddle together and walk down the path they know she must take, wanting to see how she will react. When Madame catches sight of them, her body plainly stiffens, and she clutches the shopping bag in her hand before allowing them to pass. Kathy recalls that she can still picture Madame's face, marked by "the shudder she seemed to be suppressing, the real dread that one of us would accidentally brush against her," and that she only later recognizes that Ruth had been right, that Madame really "was afraid of us in the same way someone might be afraid of spiders" (*Never Let Me Go* 35). In that moment, the clones understand that in the eyes of others they are aligned with creatures that trigger an instinctive recoil. For these children, who have been taught from an early age to be civilized and well behaved, the experience is both uncanny and wounding. Kathy describes it as feeling as if they had "walked from the sun right into chilly shade" (35). For the first time they become fully aware of the rift between the "students" they are supposed to be, an identity constantly reinforced within Hailsham, and the visceral responses they elicit in the humans who encounter them. In Madame's instinctive withdrawal, they are not treated as students to be nurtured, but as bodies to be avoided, feared and marked as other. Another carefully staged scene at Hailsham crystallizes this complexity. As a child, Kathy listens in the classroom to the song "Never Let Me Go," cradling an imaginary baby in her arms and dreaming of the future. Watching from the corridor, the human "Madame" is moved to tears. The clones' inability to have children, together with the relentless extraction of their organs by humans, lends this scene an unspoken sadness. It becomes one of the moments in the novel where human and non-human emotions communicate most intensely, prompting us to reflect more closely on the oppression and violence that humans direct toward those deemed non-human.

Kazutaka Sugiyama approaches the difference between humans and clones through what he calls "dislocated communication," arguing that the novel builds up layers of distance between reader and narrator so that the reader's initial identification with Kathy is ultimately revealed as "misplaced," culminating in the unsettling recognition that "clones are not like us" (123). My reading moves in a different direction. I suggest that the force of *Never Let Me Go* lies not in the ultimate confirmation of an absolute difference, but in the fact that the clones are like us in biological and affective terms, while the institutions and discourses that organize their lives repeatedly classify them as "non-human," shaping those lives as lives that can be sacrificed, extracted and prematurely ended. As Agnibha Banerjee succinctly observes, "Created in laboratories and bio-engineered to be infertile, the clones in Ishiguro's text are ideologically defined as non-human commodities" ("You Were Less than Human" 3). In this respect, the regime that shapes their lives has been read as recalling "the atrocities committed on the Jews in Nazi Germany and the Africans under European (and later, American) colonialism and the slave trade," drawing attention to the ways in which certain populations are rendered expendable and their labor and bodies turned into resources for others (Banerjee, "Shadowy Objects" 666). The relation between humans and clones thus echoes patterns of extraction and unequal dependency, while at the same time displacing them onto figures who are biologically

indistinguishable from those who benefit from their sacrifice. Seen in this light, the novel invites readers not simply to register how unlike "us" the clones are, but to recognize the disturbing proximity between their curtailed lives and the fates of those human communities that have been rendered less than fully human in modern histories of colonialism, slavery and racialized violence.

The complexity of the Hailsham community reflects the dual instability of the clones' homeland and identity. Even when clones are gathered at Hailsham, their self-understanding remains constantly subject to the teachers and guardians, and the institution works to make them accept the destiny of donation in ways that feel more comfortable, even "natural." From early childhood, the clones develop an ambivalent apprehension of the body. It belongs to them, and yet it also belongs to others. They repeatedly voice this contradiction through jokes and metaphors: "when the time came, you'd be able just to unzip a bit of yourself, a kidney or something would slide out, and you'd hand it over" (*Never Let Me Go* 88). Such moments vividly echo the paradoxical condition that Rosemarie Garland-Thomson, writing from a disability studies perspective, identifies: the clones "are biologically fiercely able-bodied but socioculturally disabled in the disordered world of the story" (138). Their bodies are treated as vital resources on which human life depends for maintenance and extension, while their inner feelings and mental life are scarcely seen or valued, so that they are cast as a form of existence to be drawn on at will and discarded once used. In such a position, they struggle, at the level of both body and psyche, to find any secure place for themselves within the human world. Ishiguro, however, stages no scenes of dramatic resistance or escape, and he avoids any overtly violent confrontation between humans and clones. Within this muted regime of control, graduation from Hailsham, the departure from the only home they have known, becomes instead a crucial impetus in the clones' search for a more stable personal identity. As Kathy, Tommy, Ruth, and the others leave Hailsham behind, they enter their own diasporic trajectory. In conventional terms, diaspora is often divided, according to the subject's will and orientation, into "forced diaspora" and "voluntary diaspora." The former is typically driven by disaster or catastrophe, while the latter is framed as a chosen pursuit of a better life (He 3–4).[5] The clones' dispersal after Hailsham exceeds this binary. It is neither a compelled flight from war and famine, nor a self-directed migration in pursuit of individual advancement. The complexity of the Hailsham community thus produces a hybrid diasporic consciousness, and it also, in a more oblique way, propels the clones' ongoing search for an intelligible identity.

Exile: Clone Diaspora and the Fragmentation and Consolidation of the Memory Community

Graduating from Hailsham marks the beginning of the clones' diasporic trajectory. At the Cottages they gather into dispersed groups, loosely organized around the "homes" from which they come, and it is the shared texture of their childhood experience, and of memory's commonality, that furnishes the basis for cohesion, giving rise to a distinctive memory community. Aleida Assmann argues that the "remembered past" is "not to be equated with the objectively detached study of the past that we like to call 'history.' It is always mixed with projected identities, interpretations of the present, and the need for validation" (73). This, precisely, is the ground on which a memory community takes shape. Once the Hailsham students are stripped of their teachers' guidance and the institution's shelter, and are made to leave the warmth and comfort of the only homeland they have known, their shared memory of Hailsham moves to the center of how identity is held together, as Yugin Teo observes, "Hailsham represents not only their childhood innocence but also a site of memory that imbues their lives with a sense of collective identity" (131). Their shared memory is also the foundation for forming the "diaspora-homeland relationship" in "the context of narratives of specific history of common sympathy and origin," allowing the clones to have "meaningful allegiances and obligations" (Addis 968). Yet the Cottages, with their austere and indifferent regime of managed "freedom," cast a sense of desolation and loss over clone life. The students are told that "after Hailsham there'd be no more guardians, so we'd have to look after each other," and when some greet the Cottages' caretaker, Mr. Keffers, "he'd stare at you like you were mad" (*Never Let Me Go* 117). The contrast with the

cultivated atmosphere of care and schooling at Hailsham is stark. Against this background, the rumor of "deferrals," circulating among former Hailsham students alongside their recurrent longing for Hailsham, begins to operate as what Dominic Dean terms "conspiratorial narratives" (1132). In Dean's account, Ishiguro's characters, confronted with opaque conditions and an unforeseeable future, often devise or cling to conspiratorial explanations. Such narratives may be true; they may be entirely imagined; more often they hover between the two, marked by an irreducible ambiguity (1118). The clones' faith in "deferrals" functions, on the surface, as a conspiratorial narrative. By passing on the story that two clones who are truly in love can obtain a "deferral" of their donations, they gain a temporary psychological buffer, even if this entails a partial evasion of the truth. Yet this narrative also, in a more tragic way, registers the compliance of an oppressed group with the donation regime, directing their energy toward the pursuit of exceptional "deferrals" rather than resistance to the system itself, and quietly consolidating their position as governed subjects. At the same time, continual recollection of Hailsham sustains their imagined community, allowing them in dispersal to approach relationships and self-understanding as "students from Hailsham." As their diaspora experience unfolds, Kathy and Ruth develop sharply divergent views of the clones' future, revealing how different configurations of the memory community act upon the psyches of those who live in dispersal. Unlike many dystopian narratives that build toward rebellion or uprising as their climax, Ishiguro is less concerned here with showing the clones tearing up the structures that bind them than with tracing how, in a situation where their fate can scarcely be altered, they endure sorrow without overt resistance, guard the fragile ties of feeling and memory that remain to them, and slowly discern what is truly indispensable to their lives.

Drawing on Maurice Halbwachs's sociological inquiry into "collective memory," Aleida Assmann suggests that shared recollection is among the most powerful forces of cohesion. The stability of "collective memory" is "directly connected to the composition and nature of the group"; if the group disbanded, "its individual members lost those memories that had connected them to others" (121). After the clones graduate from Hailsham, the homeland community constituted by Hailsham as a place and by the human apparatus of supervision begins to disintegrate. What remains of "home" is carried forward primarily as a memory community. Yet dispersal also entails a thinning of collective memory, leaving the Hailsham memory community in a fractured state. This fracture draws individual clones into doubts about who they are and into bleak imaginings of what lies ahead. Midway through the novel, when Ruth sets out to find her "*possible*" (*Never Let Me Go* 139), she is seized by an unusual excitement. For a moment, her sense of self no longer depends on being from Hailsham, but attaches itself to the figure of an office worker in a life far removed from the seaside towns the clones inhabit. This possible allows the clones to "glimpse your future" (140). In this sense, after leaving Hailsham, Ruth relocates her search for meaning and belonging onto a new object, rather than holding fast to a longing for the homeland community or attempting to reconstruct it. Her gesture thus registers, in another form, the rupture of Hailsham homeland community. Yet when the search for the possible fails, Ruth's fantasy of a professional life and a viable future collapses. Her excitement turns into a bleak anger, and she lashes out: "We're modeled from *trash*" (166), she says, imagining that clones are copied from addicts, prostitutes, drifters, alcoholics, and even criminals. Ruth comes to see the clones as beings "[f]ormed out of the metaphorical and literal lifeless waste of humanity," and as subjects who "can never become part of the world they observe with such fascination" (Tsao 217). The moment recalls, in a different register, the gesture in Frankenstein in which the creature casts himself as both Adam and Satan within Milton's epic, and finds himself, like Ruth, "wretched, helpless, and alone" (Shelley 105). Tsao therefore argues that "If we are meant to view the monster's relationship to 'godlike' humanity as akin to that of Milton's Adam or Satan to God the Father, by extension, Ishiguro's clones too are to human society as Adam/Satan is to God" (217). With the failure of the only search for a possible the novel stages, Ruth's hope for an affirmative, vital, distinctive identity gives way to collapse, and her psychic crisis becomes one symptom of what it means to face the disintegration of a memory community. This crisis is not merely Ruth's private trajectory. It also discloses a shared predicament for the dispersed clone community as a whole. Their exile, together

with their desire for belonging and belief, and the repeated frustration of that desire, lays bare the cruelty and indifference through which humans maintain their domination over those they deem non-human.

In the face of an identity crisis, Kathy responds in a manner quite different from Ruth's collapse and pessimism. Describing the work of remembering in Ishiguro's fiction, Peter Sloane suggests that Ishiguro's protagonists "each recall moments where they have somehow misunderstood or been misunderstood in ways which, although seemingly 'pretty innocuous,' turned out to have great importance." Attentive, in a recognizably modernist aesthetic, to narrative "unreliability," Ishiguro traces how the reworking of unreliable memory can, to some extent, make accommodation possible (*Gestural Poetics* 38). Kathy's nostalgic reconstruction of Hailsham serves as a crucial mental resource to dispel loneliness and navigate the coexistence between humans and non-humans. During her exile, Kathy also senses the rupture of the collective memories shared with other Hailsham clones. When she arrives at the Cottages, she is anxious about her surroundings, slow to trust, and reluctant to speak with students from outside Hailsham. Instead, she turns to the "last task from Hailsham," the habit of essay-writing, to attempt to "keep us afloat in our new surroundings" (*Never Let Me Go* 115). Writing, together with photographs, becomes a kind of ritual through which she reenters a shared Hailsham identity. Her sense of belonging to Hailsham is deeply cherished, and it stands in stark contrast to the coercive system by which humans established Hailsham in order to regulate and profit from clone life. As Mark Currie observes, Kathy consistently maintains "the recollection of anticipation" (94), and "to explain past events in the light of later events, and therefore to confer on those events a significance that they did not possess at the time of their occurrence" (97). This optimism fosters the consolidation of the memory community. For Kathy, the most troubling prospect is not simply the injustice of donation and death, nor the fact of being used, but the closure of the school she loves and the growing distance of her childhood from the present. After choosing to become a carer, she seeks out opportunities to reunite with Tommy and Ruth, and attempts to drive in search of Hailsham, as if to complete a memory ritual rooted in what they once shared. Jan Assmann emphasizes that "[a]ll rituals combine these two elements of repetition and representation or presentification" (3). The repeated act of revisiting, together with the self-directed decision of the three of them to undertake the journey, constitutes such a memory ritual, through which remembrance is continually reinterpreted. Even if the warmth of remembered Hailsham stands in sharp contrast to the desolation of what they find, the trio's shared journey sustains, however briefly, a threatened homeland community that has begun to fracture. This limited form of resistance, in turn, also throws into relief the latent violence that the human world holds over non-human life.

Through his depiction of the divergent lives the clones lead in diaspora, Ishiguro gradually reveals the tensions inherent in the memory community. Rebecca Walkowitz argues that Ishiguro's "cosmopolitan style" often situates narrative at the micro-level of individual experience, insisting that "global action cannot (indeed, does not) ignore the microintimacies of domesticity" (31). In his works prior to *Never Let Me Go*, stories of immigration or of the world wars are likewise filtered through such intimate details as generational conflicts between parents and children, an individual's professional ethos, and attachments in love that are never fulfilled. In *Never Let Me Go*, Ishiguro returns once more to questions of education and art, while focusing more intensively on multiple dimensions of intimacy, above all, on how memory, objects, and affective ties interact to sustain the diasporic imagination of community and the construction of identity among the clones. Kathy, Ruth, and Tommy palpably experience the cohesive power of their shared homeland identity through rituals such as reunions and revisits to their childhood homeland. Within this memory community, they find a sense of safety and belonging, and they acquire a measure of faith and perseverance even as their bodies are gradually weakened by successive donations. The personal items preserved from Hailsham, such as Kathy's cherished tape, function as key carriers of memory and become bonds of shared identity once they have left the school. Their diasporic trajectory includes a period of living at the Cottages alongside clones from different "homes," followed by Kathy's work as a carer and Ruth and Tommy's entry into their donor lives. Although their friendship is repeatedly tested and fractured over the course of

dispersal, and although the three are both forcibly separated and voluntarily reunited across different geographical spaces, their eventual pursuit of shared memories embodies the dispersed individuals' persistent desire for a sense of belonging to a communal homeland.

The whole of *Never Let Me Go* is woven out of Kathy's narrative of recollection. Her repeated returns to memories of Hailsham not only move the story forward but also, in the very act of narration, continually summon a Hailsham-centered memory community. This memory community performs a double function in the text. At the level of narrative, it provides a central hinge for organizing remembered material and stitching together otherwise disconnected episodes. At the level of identity, it offers the exiled clones a framework through which to construct a sense of self grounded in a history they can call their own. As Jingrong Zhao observes, "from a diachronic perspective, the process of identity formation is essentially the construction of an individual's history, where the temporal dimensions of past, present, and future collectively influence this process. The individual's corporeality and the associated ways of sensuously apprehending the world are central to identification" (20). Over the course of the clones' diaspora, the fragmentation and consolidation of the Hailsham memory community thus shape individual identity in decisive ways: feelings of rootlessness, worthlessness and futility about the future are, to some extent, attenuated as different memory rituals unfold and the memory community gradually coheres again. Maria Ostrovskaya reads *Never Let Me Go* as marked by a "sinister undertone." In her account, the fragmentary quality of Kathy's recollections runs in parallel with the way the clones are "literally taken apart," and Kathy's narrative is understood as "reconstituting something that has been dismembered" and recuperating "the totality of their bodies" (139–40). I do not dispute her account of the parallel structure between the clones' bodily "dismantling" and the "reassembling" of memory. Yet I would argue that the crucial force of Kathy's retrospective narration lies not in bringing about any putative "repair," but in holding bodily mutilation and emotional richness side by side over time, generating an intractable tension that compels the reader to confront the donation system as a cruelty that cannot be easily remedied.

It is precisely this combination of bodily incompleteness and intricate affect that gives the novel its most powerful charge and reflective force. The Hailsham memory community does not merely overturn the novel's internal assumption that clones are soulless; it also reveals that those who have been rendered non-human by policy and discourse possess emotional depth and moral character every bit as complex and complete as those of humans. However, often they are transferred from place to place and, however, many times their bodies are harvested, the Hailsham memory community remains an inalienable part of Kathy and her childhood companions, something that cannot be removed or erased. In the course of exile, the forms of identity and affective recognition generated through this memory community enable the ties between Kathy, Ruth and Tommy to be repaired and deepened, producing a dense emotional bond among these non-human subjects that exceeds the familiar categories of friendship, kinship and romantic love. This apparently unbreakable bond functions, on the one hand, as a tacit form of resistance to the donation programme and, on the other, as a crucial source of faith that allows them to face their donor destinies with a measure of steadiness.

Return: Non-Places, Revisiting the Community, and Reconstruction of a Spiritual Homeland

The clones' inevitable fate of nearing death through organ donations forms the basis of their community during dispersal, with shared childhood experiences at Hailsham serving as the emotional bond among Kathy, Tommy, and Ruth. Their diaspora experience after graduating from Hailsham aligns with Gabriel Sheffer's idea of "historical diasporas" (36), characterized by individuals whose "residual sentiments about their homelands and their sense of connectedness have helped them to overcome the many traumas" (55). They regard their homeland as "highly cherished places," and their memories of homeland are "the most potent motivation for actively trying to return" (55). Thus, the homeland becomes a product of "gradual crystallization," and in Sheffer's terms "facilitated the emergence of a combined primordial and psychological/symbolic identity closely connected to the

homeland" (56). However, the closure of the Hailsham homeland community coincides with the loss of its vitality and foreshadows the clones' bleak fate of becoming instrumentalized and privatized by humans. Within the novel's narrative design, Hailsham once operated as a publicly supported experiment in the "humane" nurturing of clones. With advances in genetic medicine, however, public anxiety about cloning intensified, and support for Hailsham ebbed until the school was shut down by external decision.

Ishiguro brings this history into view when Kathy and Tommy go to the address Ruth has given them, hoping to secure a deferral. Madame, once closely associated with Hailsham, is now involved in a gallery, and it is in her house that Miss Emily reveals the truth about the Hailsham project to them. When meeting Miss Emily, Kathy questions, "Why did we do all of that work in the first place? Why train us, encourage us, make us produce all of that? If we're just going to give donations anyway, then die, why all those lessons? Why all those books and discussions?" (*Never Let Me Go* 259). Miss Emily promptly replies, "We did it to *prove you had souls at all*" (260). Furthermore, Miss Emily explains that she and Madame Marie-Claude aimed to prove that "if students were reared in humane, cultivated environments, it was possible for them to grow to be as sensitive and intelligent as any ordinary human being" rather than being designed to "supply medical science" (261). Thus, the complexity of the Hailsham homeland community unfolds once more. Humans treat the preservation of the clones' artworks from Hailsham as a generous gesture, yet they feel no guilt for the regime of control and oppression imposed on the clones. This moment of disclosure to Kathy and Tommy not only projects an enthusiastic rhetoric of care and responsibility toward the non-human but also harbors hostility and a gulf between human and non-human that proves difficult to cross. At the same time, this scene establishes a measured "reflective distance" between text and reader, shifting our attention from the model of cultivation designed for the clones to a more unsettling recognition of the affinities between their designated fate and our own.

For the clones who graduate from Hailsham, the Hailsham homeland community continues to provide solace for the dispersed clones. Benedict Anderson posits that "all communities larger than primordial villages of face-to-face contact (and perhaps even these) are imagined. Communities are to be distinguished, not by their falsity/genuineness, but by the style in which they are imagined" (6). He emphasizes that a shared historical memory, common values, and symbolic representations collectively shape people's imagination of a community. The clones' sense of identity and belonging to Hailsham also stems from these shared elements. Hailsham's closure is therefore, for them, an unmistakably brutal psychic wound. Edward Said argues that exile fundamentally presents a tragic manifestation of fate, signifying "the unhealable rift forced between a human being and a native place, between the self and its true home," resulting in "a condition of terminal loss" for the exiled (173). In the novel, the clones consistently regard Hailsham, the place of their childhood, as homeland, sustaining a memory community in an attempt to heal the rift and sorrow. At the same time, Norfolk, a recurring spatial motif in the novel, offers Kathy a further source of hope and inward strength. As Robert Eaglestone observes, "agency is a central issue in all of Ishiguro's fiction" (225). In *Never Let Me Go*, I argue that agency resides less in resistance than in persistence, in the effort to hold on to those one loves and the small things one learns to cherish. In this way, the novel's quiet account of agency also delicately echoes the meaning of its title, *Never Let Me Go*. Ishiguro does not foreground the clones' opposition to the system. Instead, through a careful rendering of their genuine attachments, and through their regard for memory and for minor objects, he reframes agency as a meaning-bearing practice that makes life endurable. Kathy's repeated returns to Norfolk are a crucial expression of this practice.

Norfolk functions as a key geographical figure for the clones' diasporic lives, not least because it carries the hope of retrieval. The clones first learn about Norfolk in Miss Emily's geography class, where she describes it as "a peaceful corner of England" and calls it "A *lost corner*" (*Never Let Me Go* 65). From that point, they begin to associate this "lost corner" with Hailsham's collection point for lost property, imagining that "Norfolk was England's 'lost corner,' where all the lost property found in the country ended up" (66). Ruth, in particular, holds fast to the belief that: "when we lost something

precious, and we'd looked and looked and still couldn't find it, then we didn't have to be completely heartbroken. We still had that last bit of comfort, thinking one day, when we were grown up, and we were free to travel around the country, we could always go and find it again in Norfolk" (66). To define Norfolk as "a lost corner," of course, disposes readers to approach it in terms of loss. Andrew Bennett accordingly reads Norfolk as "the geographical symbol of the illusion of an impossible (re)discovery of that which is experienced as lost even while it was never possessed in the first place" (18). Ji Eun Lee, turning to the clones' bodily dispossession, argues that "[t]he definition of Norfolk as the 'lost corner' where one can find lost items, however, invites us to think 'loss' as a creative term that can denote an identity of a place and potentially the subjectivity of the clones who are destined to lose their bodies" (278). Yet I do not fully accept that Norfolk remains, throughout, under the shadow of the irrecoverable, nor that it must be read as a fatalistic emblem of the clones' destined bodily loss. For Kathy, Norfolk matters precisely because it promises a possibility of retrieval. That retrieval may be material, as when she finds again in a Norfolk secondhand shop the cassette she lost in childhood; it may also be affective, as when, after Tommy's death, she repeatedly imagines in the Norfolk fields the sea washing his figure ashore, and a scene of meeting him again by the coast. It is this promise of retrieval that enables Kathy, in diaspora, to return to memory as a practice through which the meaning of a life can still be remade. As Asami Nakamura suggests, *Never Let Me Go* offers "a philosophy of reclaiming and repurposing what has been given through remembrance," tracing, within the regulated trajectory of the clones' lives, an "affective cartography of hope" that exists "between despair and submission" (64). Norfolk, I argue, is a crucial point in this affective cartography. The childhood fantasy that "all the lost property found in the country" will be sent there does not simply vanish with Hailsham's closure; rather, Norfolk's sustaining hope of "finding again" opens a renewed way of thinking about "home" for those in diaspora. Norfolk is not Kathy's home in any literal geographical sense, since her true home remains Hailsham; but through repeated acts of searching and imagining, it becomes a place where she can pause, receive a measure of spiritual consolation, and inhabit what might be called a diasporic homeland of the mind.

In the closing pages of *Never Let Me Go*, Ishiguro turns the Norfolk field into a "non-place" that enables Kathy's imagined return to community, and, with it, a momentary rebuilding of spiritual homeland after the loss of her closest companions and childhood sanctuary. The concept of "non-places" was proposed by the French anthropologist Marc Augé, and is set against the "anthropological places." As Augé puts it, places "have at least three characteristics in common" and are expected to be "places of identity, of relations and of history" (52). Non-places, lacking these characteristics, are typically homogenized spaces such as stations or supermarkets. When a person enters the space of non-place, he is "relieved of his usual determinants" and becomes "no more than what he does or experiences in the role of passenger, customer or driver" (77–78, 103). The Norfolk fields in the novel constitute such a "non-place." It is not anchored in a shared past. People pass through from different directions and disperse again, without any sustained historical attachment. Located by a road, the traffic it attracts is random; there is no stable, unified community, no settled place-identity, and no fixed web of interpersonal relations. More importantly, it is also a space that crosses racial boundaries, traversable by both humans and non-humans. In this non-place, Kathy can, for a moment, set aside the social norms and hierarchies of the outside world. She can step back from her role as a "carer," and from the impending horizon of donation and death, and stand, briefly, as a passerby watching the landscape. For this reason, the scene by the fields becomes one of the most affecting moments in the book. She looks at "the rubbish, the flapping plastic in the branches, the shore-line of odd stuff caught along the fencing," and imagines that "this was the spot where everything I'd ever lost since my childhood had washed up," while the dead Tommy waves to her in greeting (*Never Let Me Go* 287). In that instant, Kathy returns to the Hailsham homeland community. The memory community, internalized as belief, becomes a spiritual force that allows her to imagine everything lost meeting again here. Her experience of time and space in this non-place is thus both a mode of self-healing after trauma and a reconstruction of spiritual homeland. Although Hailsham has been forcibly closed, it is no longer merely the name of a site, but a community that carries memory, identity, and conviction.

Through this return and reconstruction, she reenters those precious feelings from the past and tastes, however briefly, the joy of recovery. She attains a sense of inner wholeness, a stance that pushes back against the worldview imposed on most of the oppressed. This stance steadies her after the loss of those dearest to her, and it also unsettles any simple binary between living and dying.

From another angle, the Norfolk fields also encode the notion of "Thirdspace." They are a site where life and death intersect, and where reality and imagination converge, yet they are fully neither. Rather, they open up a new kind of space, "a *Thirdspace of political choice* that is also a meeting place for all peripheralized or marginalized 'subjects' wherever they may be located" (Soja 35). The closing scene invites the reader into this Thirdspace as well. It prompts a retrospective view of Kathy, Ruth, and Tommy, and of their attempt to express a soul through art, rather than exist only as a supply of organs for humans. The Norfolk fields gather their thwarted efforts at the novel's end, and they establish between text and reader a relation that exceeds a simple master – slave opposition between human and non-human. What emerges instead is a relation of reflection and correspondence, in which the emotional and mortal experience of the non-human becomes a means of thinking again about meaning and value in human life. As Ming Tong observes, "homeland is both an actual geo-spatial location and an imagined space; homeland need not be the place to which fallen leaves return, but may also be one station in the journey of life" (52). Unlike Stevens's belated return in *The Remains of the Day*, Kathy is not marked by the regret of a life misconstrued, nor does she linger in the Norfolk fields as a way of evading grief. Ishiguro allows her, briefly, to reconstruct a spiritual homeland in which all that has been lost, people and things alike, might be gathered, and then he has her drive on "to wherever it was I was supposed to be" (*Never Let Me Go* 288). He does not dwell on the spectacle of her devastation at losing her beloved. Instead, he chooses another path, concentrating his meditation in the imagined scene by the Norfolk fields. Within this space, questions of life and death, the value of a life, and the relation between human and non-human are compressed with unusual intensity.

Kathy's imaginative revisiting of the Norfolk coast juxtaposes two opposing forces within a single visual frame, rendering the novel's conclusion all the more poignant and mournful: on the one hand, there is the solace brought by memory and imagined community, which allows her to face her imminent death alone; on the other hand, there remains the dehumanizing logic of a society that fixes clones in the role of pure utility, as bodies to be used. In a recent radical reading, Peter Sloane questions the ontological status of these "clones," arguing that they may in fact represent real, marginalized human beings. The so-called "clone myth," he suggests, is a metaphorical construction, designed to serve the state's organ donation system and soothe the collective conscience. In his view, the true meaning of "clones" is simply those who are "'alone,' unwanted, orphaned, ultimately let go" ("When We Were Humans" 21). Most ironically, this myth is not imposed from above, but is sustained through the shared belief of both characters and readers. Kathy's nostalgia and her silent acceptance of the donation regime may, in this light, be understood as products of an internalized state ideology. Sloane thus categorizes *Never Let Me Go* as a work of "*silence* fiction," a narrative mode that brings to the surface those social traumas which remain unspoken ("When We Were Humans" 32). This constructed "silence" finds an uncanny parallel in real-world controversies over organ harvesting in Britain. Between the 1980s and 1990s, Liverpool's Alder Hey Children's Hospital was revealed to have illegally retained vast numbers of infant organs and fetal bodies, triggering a nationwide scandal. The subsequent *Redfern Report* (2001) exposed practices of non-consensual organ collection across NHS hospitals, ultimately leading to the *Human Tissue Act* (2004), which reaffirmed informed consent as a core ethical principle. According to Sloane, *Never Let Me Go* was written precisely across the temporal threshold of this ethical crisis and legislative reform. The novel's internal logic, its legalized clone-donation system, therefore speaks back to the medical treatment of expendable bodies in contemporary British public health debates, doing so in subtle yet deeply resonant ways ("When We Were Humans" 32). Yet the power of the novel does not end here. This radical reading does not erase the positive significance that memory and community hold for Kathy. Her gaze over the Norfolk fields is, on one level, an imagined reunion with the loved ones and lost objects of her life;

on another, it allows the power of remembered love and attachment to kindle a faint spark of resistance against fate. It is a form of extremely restrained mourning that guides her calmly toward her final resting place. At this point, *Never Let Me Go* offers neither a definitive revelation nor a sentimental romantic conclusion. Instead, it leaves the reader suspended in a gray zone where no choice is straightforward: are the clones human or non-human? Are they distant others, or projections of ourselves? Do we have the courage to tear apart the "myth" itself, or do we, like Kathy, choose to journey to the end within the illusion, accompanied by our memories?

Many readers tend to regard *Never Let Me Go* as Ishiguro's bleakest and most tragic novel. Ishiguro himself, however, has commented in an interview that "Actually, I always thought of *Never Let Me Go* as my cheerful novel [. . .] With *Never Let Me Go* I felt that for the first time I had given myself permission to focus on the positive aspects of human beings" (Hunnewell). Hunt likewise observes that "[t]he friendship of the clones in the face of their premature death is far from tragic" (187). I would similarly suggest that, although Ishiguro does not shy away from the cruelty of the organ-donation programme or the violence of lives reduced to pure instrumentality, the novel's emotional force is not confined to desolation. It lies instead in the delicacy of the bonds among the clones and in their careful cherishing of shared memory as they approach death. Their community is not sustained by unalloyed kindness. The clones experience jealousy, resentment, possessiveness and guilt as well as loyalty and care. Ruth's repeated interference in Kathy's relationship with Tommy, and Kathy's own muted sense of grievance and suppression, reveal the intricate emotional layers that structure the clones' diaspora community. This is not a community held together only by selfless warmth, but one woven out of feelings that can wound as well as sustain. Precisely these "less than ideal" emotions, recalled and reflected on alongside affection and fidelity as their lives unfold in diaspora, allow their emotional ties to grow increasingly firm and irreplaceable over time. This affective texture, made up of both light and shadow, is the key force that holds the clones' diaspora community together and, I would suggest, the most compelling aspect of the novel. Moreover, across Ishiguro's broader creative trajectory, his sustained exploration of non-human beings and love also generates another kind of guarded positivity in *Klara and the Sun*. As he remarks, "By presenting a very difficult world you can show the brightness, you can show the sunniness" (Allardice). Both the clones, treated as living banks of organs, and Klara, built as a companion robot, occupy structurally marginal positions as non-human. Yet the clones, through the refinement of their attachments and the acuity of their feelings, foreground a fully human capacity for love and loyalty, while Klara's almost flawless mechanical design throws into relief the fact that it is precisely imperfect, incomplete love that gives the human heart its distinctive value. Through his sustained writing of love, memory, and imagined homelands, Ishiguro invites readers to reconsider how those marked as "non-human" may disclose, with particular clarity, what is most fragile and most valuable in human life.

Returning to *Never Let Me Go* itself, the diaspora community of clones is defined by a constant pattern of removal, dispersal and brief reunion. They are sent out from Hailsham to the Cottages, move from being "students" to becoming donors and carers, and are then repeatedly transferred to different recovery centers and other facilities. Their geographic movements and shifting roles mean that they inhabit a life in which they are always scattered, like dandelion seeds carried by the wind, and rarely granted a place where they can genuinely settle. Yet along this trajectory, memories of Hailsham, the imagined landscape of Norfolk and their enduring attachments to one another repeatedly draw them back into a community structured around memory. As Kathy puts it, "Once I'm able to have a quieter life, in whichever center they send me to, I'll have Hailsham with me, safely in my head, and that'll be something no one can take away" (*Never Let Me Go* 286–287). This community, formed by subjects designated as "non-human," exposes, on the one hand, how a donation system that depends on the bodies of others brutally marks certain lives as "available for use." On the other hand, it shows that even under diasporic conditions, love, memory and the imagined home continue to offer solitary individuals a sense of belonging and even of happiness. Within this tension between dispersal and return, *Never Let Me Go* weaves together non-human narrative, diasporic experience and shapes of community. The brief lives of the clones thereby become a veiled inquiry into what it means to be

human in the contemporary world, and they provide a starting point for rethinking how communities take shape and where, under such conditions, "home" might be found.

Conclusion

Ishiguro never tells us where Kathy finally drives to, and we cannot, in any case, arrive at a definitive answer to the questions raised above from the novel alone. Rather, as time passes, the novel continues to take on new shapes of meaning for us. This article likewise has no wish to offer definitive answers to these questions, in keeping with Ishiguro's characteristic narrative manner, in which his prose often presents "its surface's deceitful sheen which inevitably eludes the mind's grasp" (Sloane, *Gestural Poetics* 163). It is precisely this layered and ambiguous quality that has provided the starting point for the present reading: the ever-shifting, never fully stabilized shapes of the diaspora community offer one way of approaching the novel's meanings. Across the clones' trajectory of cohesion, exile and return, their story is not only about the sorrow of dispossession and expulsion but also about the importance of memory, love and homeland for those who live in diaspora. As Amy Christmas observes, "In *Never Let Me Go*, love is imperative to the contemporary human condition because it provides a space within which we can escape the flattening excesses of postmodernity and reassert our individuality, if only through the eyes of our lovers" (408). Here, "return" is no longer confined to a physical homecoming, but becomes a spiritual homeland rebuilt out of cherished memories, love, and the imagined significance of particular objects or places, and for that very reason cannot be seized or taken away. If we follow these shifting forms of diaspora and return, we may come to see the brief lives of the clones as a mirror that not only reflects how, in our own daily existence, we live with distance, nostalgia and the desire to belong, but also, once the less important dust has been gently filtered away, quietly invites us to devote our limited time to love and to those we call home.

In *Never Let Me Go*, Ishiguro's depiction of the clones' diasporic experiences and emotional bonds stands in a mutually illuminating relation to his own reflections on identity after moving to Britain and his long-standing concern with memory. At the age of five, he left Japan with his parents for the United Kingdom and soon became acutely aware of the frictions between different cultural worlds and the tensions of speaking across them. This sensitivity is reflected in his writing, which pays close attention to patterns of exclusion and incorporation not only between racial groups but also between species. His delicate portrayal of the dispersed clone community also carries his longing for Japan, the country in which he spent only a brief part of his early childhood. In his Nobel Lecture, he recalls "I was busily constructing in my mind a richly detailed place called 'Japan' – a place to which I in some way belonged, and from which I drew a certain sense of my identity and my confidence" (Ishiguro, "My Twentieth Century Evening"). Because he lacks sustained experience of growing up in Japan, both his remembered Japan and the Japans he creates in his fiction are marked by an imaginative quality. This is strikingly similar to the way Kathy and the other clones relate to Hailsham. Nourished by both Eastern and Western cultural traditions, Ishiguro develops a perspective that is at once open and inclusive, while allowing him to approach non-human themes with a certain clarity and distance. As a result, readers are able to recognize themselves in the clones' stories, through which the novel offers a restrained yet piercing reflection on the value and meaning of human life.

Ishiguro's shaping of relationships in the novel also speaks to the change in creative consciousness that led him to describe *Never Let Me Go* as a departure. I was fortunate to have the opportunity to speak with Ishiguro, and to suggest that, unlike his earlier works which tend to focus on individuals who evade their pasts, this novel is much more concerned with communities. He replied that as he has grown older, and as society has changed, the focus of his writing has naturally shifted. He has come to feel that it is no longer sufficient to discuss memory only at the individual level. His writing, he explained, "has moved from examining people just at their individual level, struggling with the question of remembering and forgetting, to trying to understand what the relationship is between that problem and the struggle in society."[6] *Never Let Me Go* can be read as one response to this shift. By using clones as a non-human device, Ishiguro

constructs a narrative that mirrors the formation of a diaspora community, and in doing so brings questions of diaspora literature and "a community with a shared future for humankind" into the frame. Through his sustained depiction of the clones' cohesion, exile and return, the diaspora community is shaped into a vessel that carries images of a warm homeland, precious childhood memories and imagined reconstructions of home, threading through the lives of the dispersed clones in rich and varied ways. In this way, Ishiguro portrays Kathy's search for personal value, her tracing of the brief lives of her closest companions, and her complex efforts to reach a form of self-reconciliation within the community. At the same time, he highlights the pressures on diasporic identity in a globalized context and urges us to reconsider the limits and dangers of anthropocentrism.

Notes

1. For this and subsequent quotations from Ishiguro's lecture, see Kazuo Ishiguro in conversation with John Mullan (Head of UCL English) at the 2025 Northcliffe Lecture, University College London, 18 March 2025. The event formed part of UCL English's annual Northcliffe Lecture series and took the form of a chronological discussion of Ishiguro's fictional oeuvre. All quotations are transcribed from the author's notes as a member of the audience.
2. Unless otherwise noted, translations of Chinese-language sources in the main text and notes are the author's.
3. As Biwu Shang argues, non-human narratives do not displace literature's long-standing concern with the human; rather, by widening the representational field to include non-human beings, they sharpen our sense of the relations that bind the human and the non-human. In identifying Chinese precedents for such narration, Shang turns to *zhiguai* tales of the strange and anomalous and *shenmo* gods-and-demons narratives, including the *Shan hai jing* (*Classic of Mountains and Seas*), Pu Songling's *Liaozhai zhiyi* (*Strange Tales from a Chinese Studio*), and Wu Cheng'en's *Xiyou ji* (*Journey to the West*). These traditions, he suggests, provide rich narrative frameworks in which non-human beings can occupy sustained positions of agency. The *Shan hai jing*, for example, is organized "by places rather than by times or by human figures," so that mountains, rivers, plants, and animals can emerge as narratable subjects in their own right. Read together, these precedents underscore that literary writing has never been confined to the human alone, and they supply a longer historical frame, grounded in Chinese narrative practice, for current discussions of the "turn to the non-human" (122–25).
4. In developing my use of diaspora, I draw on Ming Tong's account of *feisan* as a distinctively Chinese way of rethinking dispersal. Tong presents diaspora not as a neutral description of mobility but as a critical perspective animated by a "logic of transcendence," one that approaches national culture with trans-ethnic openness and extends the idea of home through translation. Without denying the darker shadows of history, this perspective nonetheless turns toward an affirmation of life. Tong further emphasizes that, whatever challenges "foreign lands" and other cultures may bring, diaspora ultimately affirms the value of the "foreign": fear of foreigners discloses the borders we have internalized, whereas accepting the foreign other teaches us to cross those borders and to recognize that difference within the self is also a form of "elsewhere" (59).
5. This distinction between "forced" and "voluntary" diaspora follows Weihua He's discussion of diaspora in the context of contemporary globalization. He argues that, despite ongoing injustice, exploitation and oppression, diaspora communities and diaspora studies can function as a positive political force, contributing to the construction of a more just, equitable and harmonious "community with a shared future for humankind." She further contends that, as cross-border exchange and international co-operation become more frequent and many problems are shared across countries, sustained translation, evaluation and critical engagement with developments in Western theory can provide crucial resources for reorienting literary theory in China – so that, to use the Chinese proverb, "the stone from other hills may serve to polish our jade" (1, 7).
6. Ishiguro's response to the author's question during the Q&A; see the Northcliffe Lecture cited above.

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